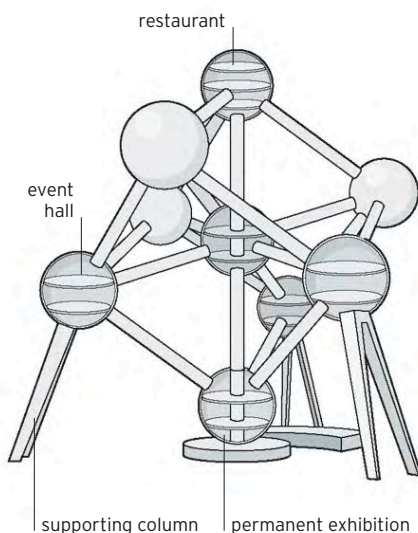


STRENGTHENING THE ATOMIUM

When originally conceived, the Atomium was to be free-standing, resting on its lowest sphere. Wind tunnel tests suggested, however, that it would have toppled over in winds of 50 mph (80 kph). Hence, three pairs of support columns were added to stabilize the structure by supporting the three main lower spheres. Emergency stairs were also added as a precaution.



< NEW SKIN

The spheres of the giant iron atom were originally coated with aluminum, which began to corrode. The coating was replaced with stainless steel in 2001 to ensure that it was corrosion-resistant and matched modern architectural standards.



△ ACCESSIBLE ATOMS

Six of the nine spheres in use are connected by stairs, escalators, and an elevator that runs up the vertical central tube.

Stoclet Palace

A Modernist Viennese mansion, a “total work of art” set in the heart of Brussels



Adolphe Stoclet (1871–1949) was a wealthy Belgian industrialist and director of the Société Générale de Belgique, one of the largest investment companies in Belgium. While in Vienna to oversee the construction of a railway, he met one of the leading lights of the Vienna Secession art movement, the architect Josef Hoffmann (1870–1956). Stoclet shared Hoffmann's avant-garde taste and asked him to design a house for him in Brussels.

Attention to detail

The resulting house is Hoffmann's masterpiece, a remarkable synthesis of the arts (*Gesamtkunstwerk*) and one of the most luxurious private houses of the 20th century. Asymmetrical in outline, its stark, rectangular exterior hides a refined, almost theatrical interior, with geometric furniture and rich decoration. Hoffmann designed every aspect of the building, right down to its door handles and wall paintings. Although a UNESCO World Heritage Site, the house is still occupied by the Stoclet family and thus not open to visitors.



△ SOFTENING THE LINES

The straight-lined exterior of the palace is softened by the windows that break through the eaves and the upright Art Nouveau balustrades that surround the balconies.

Einstein Tower

An Expressionist observatory designed to test Einstein's revolutionary theories



In 1911, Albert Einstein (1879–1955) published his *General Theory of Relativity*. One of the theory's predicted effects was a slight increase in the wavelength of light escaping from a strong gravitational field—a phenomenon known as gravitational redshift. German astronomers led by Erwin Finlay-Freundlich (1885–1964) decided to test the theory and commissioned a new solar observatory in Potsdam, outside Berlin, to be named after Einstein.

Dedicated to physics

The German architect Erich Mendelsohn (1887–1953) set out to create a building with a dynamic structure that would align with Einstein's radical theories. He opted to build the tower from reinforced concrete, suitable for its sculpted form. Construction difficulties caused by the complexity of the design, together with material shortages during World War I, meant that the observatory was actually built of brick and then covered with stucco. The designer achieved his vision for the building, however, with Einstein himself remarking on its “organic” form.



△ SCULPTED APPEARANCE

The building is curvilinear without any right angles, the soft corners and sinuous lines giving it a flowing look. It has been likened to the building in illustrations of the nursery rhyme about the old lady who lived in a shoe.